

CIVICS & COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

# Ethics in Community Work

*Power · Accountability · Do No Harm · Dissent · Volunteering · Conflict*



# What We Will Cover in This Module

01

## Power & Vulnerability

Who holds power in community work and what ethical responsibilities does that create?

02

## Accountability & Transparency

How to handle money, make claims, and report honestly — even when uncomfortable.

03

## Do No Harm

The foundational principle of ethical community engagement and how harm happens unintentionally.

04

## Non-Violence & Dissent

Principled non-violence, civility in civic life, and how to disagree without destroying.

05

## Ethics of Volunteering

When helping hurts — the ethics of volunteerism, aid dependency, and the saviour complex.

06

## Managing Conflict

Sources of conflict in teams and communities, and proven approaches to resolution.

# Ethics in Community Work: Power and Responsibility

Ethics in community work begins with a simple question: who has power here — and what do they owe the people they are working with? Power is not only about politics or authority. It is embedded in every relationship between a practitioner, volunteer, or organisation and a community.

## Understanding Power in Community Contexts

### Institutional Power

Power held by organisations, NGOs, or government. Includes legal authority, funding control, and ability to approve or deny requests — creating inherent power imbalances with communities.

### Knowledge Power

Practitioners arrive with technical expertise and professional language that communities lack. This can unintentionally marginalise local knowledge, which is often more relevant than technical reports.

### Resource Power

Control over money, equipment, and networks. When the practitioner holds the budget and the community depends on it, the community's ability to disagree or redirect the project is severely limited.

### Cultural & Social Power

Some community members hold more influence due to gender, class, caste, age, or religion. Practitioners who miss these internal hierarchies may inadvertently reinforce existing inequalities.

## Ethical Responsibilities of the Practitioner

1

### Acknowledge your power explicitly

Name the power differential with communities rather than pretending it doesn't exist. 'We control this funding, but your priorities should drive its use.'

2

### Prioritise community agency

Decisions about community problems should be led by community members, not imposed by practitioners — even well-intentioned ones.

3

### Amplify, don't replace, local knowledge

Your role is to add resources and skills to what communities already know, not to substitute your expertise for theirs.

4

### Create real accountability upward

Communities must have genuine, accessible mechanisms to challenge, question, or dismiss practitioners who misuse power.

5

### Recognise intersecting inequalities

Within any community, some people have less voice than others. Ethical practitioners actively include marginalised voices — especially women, youth, minorities.

# Ethics in Community Work: Vulnerability and the Duty of Care

Vulnerability is not a fixed characteristic of a person — it is a relationship between a person's situation and the risks they face in a given context. Community workers frequently engage with individuals who are more exposed to harm, exploitation, or distress than the average person. This exposure creates a heightened ethical duty.

## Who May Be Vulnerable in Community Contexts?

### Children & Young People

Cannot legally consent. Depend on adults for safety. Uniquely susceptible to manipulation, exploitation, and long-term developmental harm from negative experiences.

### Women & Girls

Disproportionately exposed to domestic violence, displacement, food insecurity, and exclusion from decision-making. Cultural norms may prevent them from raising concerns.

### Persons with Disabilities

May face physical barriers to participation, communication challenges, or heightened risk of institutional neglect. Often excluded from 'universal' programme designs.

### Elderly Individuals

May face cognitive decline, isolation, financial dependence, or physical fragility that limits their ability to consent freely or report abuse.

### Refugees & IDPs

Lack legal status, community networks, and documentation. Highly dependent on aid actors. Extremely limited ability to challenge or refuse interventions.

### Extreme Poverty

Material need creates economic coercion. Someone who desperately needs food, shelter, or income cannot truly freely consent to participation conditions.

**Duty of Care:** When working with vulnerable groups, practitioners have a legal and ethical obligation to take reasonable steps to prevent foreseeable harm. This includes designing safeguarding policies, training staff and volunteers on abuse prevention, establishing clear reporting mechanisms, and never placing personal or organisational interests above participant safety.

# Accountability and Transparency: What They Mean in Practice

Accountability means being answerable to others for your actions, decisions, and use of resources. Transparency means making information available in ways that allow those affected to understand, question, and evaluate what you are doing and why. Both are ethical obligations — not optional best practices.

## Accountability

Accountability is the obligation to accept responsibility for your actions and to explain them to those who have a right to know — primarily the communities you serve, your funders, your organisation, and the public.

### Four dimensions:

**Downward accountability:** Accountable to communities and beneficiaries — the most important and most frequently neglected direction.

**Upward accountability:** Accountable to funders, government, and boards — often the most pressured direction, but not the most important.

**Internal accountability:** Accountable to your team, colleagues, and organisation's own values and standards.

**Horizontal accountability:** Accountable to peers, partner organisations, and professional standards.

## Transparency

Transparency is the practice of operating openly — sharing information proactively rather than waiting to be asked, explaining your reasoning, and making your processes visible to those who are affected by your decisions.

### Four dimensions:

**Financial transparency:** How money was raised, allocated, and spent — reported honestly and in accessible formats.

**Process transparency:** How decisions were made, who was consulted, what alternatives were considered and why rejected.

**Impact transparency:** What results were actually achieved — including failures, not just successes.

**Conflict of interest disclosure:** Any personal, financial, or political interests that could influence decisions must be declared openly.

# Accountability in Practice: Money, Claims, and Reporting

Abstract commitments to accountability mean nothing without concrete practices. The three highest-risk areas for ethical failure in community work are the handling of money, the making of impact claims, and the production of reports. Each area has specific practices that separate ethical from unethical conduct.

## Handling Money

**Segregation of duties:** No single person should authorise, execute, and verify a transaction. Separate these roles to prevent fraud.

**Receipts for everything:** Every expenditure needs a written receipt. If one cannot be obtained, create a signed written record at the time of payment.

**Separate accounts:** Project funds must never mix with personal funds. Use dedicated bank accounts for every project.

**Budget vs. actuals reporting:** Compare planned spending against actual spending regularly. Investigate and explain all significant variances.

**No unauthorised payments:** No payment may be made without prior authorisation from whoever holds financial responsibility.

## Making Impact Claims

**Outputs vs. outcomes:** Outputs are what you did (100 workshops). Outcomes are what measurably changed. Never conflate them.

**Attribute honestly:** Only claim change your programme demonstrably caused. Don't take credit for changes caused by others.

**Report failures too:** Honest reporting includes what did not work and why. Donors are entitled to honest accounts — not only successes.

**Use appropriate comparison:** Compare outcomes against your baseline. Without a baseline you cannot honestly claim improvement.

**No manipulation of statistics:** Do not cherry-pick data or use misleading visualisations. Present data as it is, with caveats.

## Writing Reports

**Write for the community first:** Your primary audience is the community you served, not funders. Produce a plain-language summary accessible to non-specialists.

**Include community voice:** Reports should include direct quotes and perspectives from community members — not only data or practitioner analysis.

**Be clear about methodology:** Explain how you collected data, who participated, and what the limitations of your evidence are.

**Don't hide uncomfortable findings:** Limited impact or community dissatisfaction must be reported. Burying bad news is dishonest.

**Protect identities:** Anonymise personal information in public reports unless participants explicitly consented to identification.

# The Do-No-Harm Principle in Community Engagement

**Do No Harm** is the foundational ethical principle that community practitioners must take reasonable steps to avoid causing harm through their actions, even when those actions are well-intentioned. Originally from medical ethics ('primum non nocere'), it has become central to humanitarian action, development work, and community engagement. The key insight is that **good intentions do not prevent harm** — only good practice does.

## What the Do-No-Harm Principle Requires

### Analyse Before Acting

Before designing any programme, assess the social, cultural, economic, and political context. Ask: what could go wrong? Who could be made worse off? What tensions already exist that our work could inflame?

### Consider Unintended Consequences

Every intervention creates ripple effects. A food distribution programme might undermine local farmers. A literacy programme might create tensions in families where educated children gain more power than parents.

### Consult Beneficiaries Systematically

Ask intended beneficiaries whether they think the programme will help or harm them. Their lived knowledge of local dynamics is irreplaceable and must be gathered before, during, and after implementation.

### Monitor for Harm in Real Time

Establish feedback mechanisms so that community members can report harm as it occurs — not only after the project ends. Create safe, accessible channels for this feedback.

### Stop and Adjust When Harm Occurs

If you discover your programme is causing harm, you are obligated to stop, redesign, or exit. Continuing a harmful programme to protect organisational reputation or a donor relationship is an ethical violation.

# Do No Harm: How Harm Happens in Well-Intentioned Work

Most harm caused by community practitioners is not malicious — it is the result of poor analysis, unchecked assumptions, cultural blindness, or organisational pressure. Understanding the most common pathways to harm is the first step in preventing it.

## Resource Distortion

Injecting large amounts of external money or goods into a community economy can distort local markets, create inflation, suppress local production, and generate dependency. Example: free food aid that makes local farmers unable to sell at any price.

## Community Conflict Aggravation

Targeting benefits to some community members and not others — based on crude criteria — can intensify pre-existing tensions, create envy, and even trigger violence. Selection of beneficiaries must be transparent, consultative, and defensible.

## Erosion of Local Capacity

When an external organisation does what local institutions could do, it weakens those institutions. Importing staff instead of building local skills; importing materials instead of using local suppliers — both reduce the community's long-term capacity.

## Psychological and Cultural Harm

Photographing poverty, sharing suffering publicly without consent, or conducting research without adequate debriefing can re-traumatise individuals. Cultural insensitivity can cause shame, social exclusion, or religious offence.

## Misuse of Personal Data

Collecting and storing sensitive information about beneficiaries — health status, legal status, family situations — without adequate security or consent creates serious risks if that data falls into the wrong hands.

## False Hope and Abandonment

Raising community expectations — about a school, a programme, a change — and then failing to deliver, or suddenly exiting without a transition plan, can cause serious psychological harm and reduce communities' willingness to trust future interventions.



# Non-Violence, Civility, and Respectful Dissent

In civic and community work, people regularly disagree — about priorities, methods, leadership, and values. The question is not whether conflict and disagreement will occur, but how they are handled. **Non-violence and civility are not about suppressing disagreement: they are about channelling it constructively.**

## Principled Non-Violence

Principled non-violence is a strategic and moral commitment to pursuing change through non-violent means — not merely the absence of physical violence, but the rejection of psychological coercion, intimidation, and deliberate humiliation as tools of civic action.

### Attack ideas, not people

Critique a policy, an argument, or a system — never demean, stereotype, or dehumanise the people who hold those views.

### Refuse to use fear as a tool

Do not threaten, intimidate, or leverage people's insecurities to win an argument or build support for your position.

### Maintain open dialogue

Non-violence requires keeping communication open with opponents. Refusing to engage is rarely principled — it is usually a strategic failure.

### Accept legal and social consequences

Civil disobedience should be open and acknowledged, with willingness to accept consequences — which is what gives it moral authority.

## Civility in Civic Life

Civility is respect for the humanity and dignity of those you disagree with — even when their positions are wrong. It is compatible with forceful, passionate disagreement. What it rules out is dehumanisation.

### Listen to understand, not just to respond

Genuinely engage with opposing arguments before dismissing them. Understanding why others disagree strengthens your own position.

### Acknowledge valid points in opposing views

Even deeply flawed positions usually contain a kernel of legitimate concern. Acknowledging this builds credibility and trust.

### Distinguish the argument from the person

A person can be wrong about one thing and right about another. Judge arguments on their merits, not on who makes them.

### Model the norms you want to see

Civic culture is built from the bottom up. If you want more respectful public discourse, you must practise it — especially in difficult moments.

# Ethics of Volunteering: When 'Help' Becomes Harm

Volunteering is widely considered a straightforward moral good. In reality, unethical volunteering can cause serious harm — to communities, to local economies, to professional workers whose jobs are displaced, and to the volunteers themselves. Good intentions are not sufficient. Ethical volunteering requires preparation, humility, and honest self-assessment.

## When Volunteering Causes Harm

### Skills mismatch

Volunteers who lack the skills needed for a task often produce poor-quality work — building unsafe structures, providing incorrect medical information, or delivering ineffective teaching.

### Job displacement

When qualified local professionals could do the work — but unpaid volunteers do it instead — local employment is destroyed and community capacity is undermined rather than built.

### Dependency creation

Communities that receive repeated short-term volunteer visits can become dependent on external help rather than building their own sustainable systems and leadership.

### Voluntourism harm

Short-term volunteer tourism (orphanage visits, construction projects) is often driven by the volunteer's desire for experience rather than community need. Research shows orphanage volunteering increases demand for children to be separated from families.

### The saviour complex

A saviour mindset positions the volunteer as the hero and the community as helpless victims. This is dehumanising, often racist in origin, and produces programmes that serve the volunteer's ego rather than the community's needs.

## What Ethical Volunteering Looks Like

- ✓ **Community-led design:** The community identifies the need, defines the role, and chooses the volunteer — not the other way around. Volunteers serve community priorities, not their own.
- ✓ **Matched skills:** Volunteers should only do tasks they are genuinely qualified to perform. If you would not be trusted to do this at home, you should not do it in a vulnerable community.
- ✓ **Long-term commitment:** Wherever possible, prefer sustained engagement over short visits. Relationships, trust, and meaningful contribution take time to build.
- ✓ **Building capacity, not dependency:** Ethical volunteering transfers skills and knowledge so that the community can eventually do without external volunteers. Every task should be done alongside locals, not instead of them.
- ✓ **Listening before doing:** Spend significant time understanding the community's context, history, and needs before proposing any actions. Diagnosis must precede prescription.

# Managing Conflict in Teams and with Communities

Conflict is a normal feature of community work — not a sign of failure. Teams working on complex, emotionally charged problems will disagree. Communities will push back. The question is whether conflict is managed constructively or allowed to become destructive. Unmanaged conflict is one of the leading causes of project failure.

## Conflict Within Teams

**Common sources:** Unclear roles · Unequal workloads · Differing values or backgrounds · Poor communication · Competition for recognition or resources

### Address early, not late

Small conflicts become large ones when ignored. Raise concerns at the first opportunity, in private, with the specific person involved.

### Name the behaviour, not the person

Say 'The decision was made without consulting me' not 'You are dismissive.' Focus on actions and their impact, not character.

### Seek to understand first

Before defending your position, genuinely try to understand the other person's perspective. What are they worried about? What do they need?

### Use structured mediation

For serious or persistent conflicts, use a neutral mediator — someone trusted by both parties who has no stake in the outcome.

## Conflict With Communities

**Common sources:** Broken promises · Exclusion from decisions · Cultural insensitivity · Perception of disrespect · Resource disputes · Misaligned expectations

### Acknowledge and validate

Genuinely acknowledge the community's concerns — even if you disagree. This is not weakness; it is the start of respectful engagement.

### Create safe feedback spaces

Not everyone will speak up in a large meeting. Use multiple channels: one-on-one conversations, anonymous feedback, or separate sessions.

### Be honest about constraints

If something cannot change, explain why honestly. Communities tolerate genuine limitations far better than deception or evasion.

### Follow through on commitments

The fastest way to rebuild trust after conflict is doing what you said you would do. Broken follow-through deepens and entrenches conflict.

# Conflict Escalation, De-escalation, and the Ladder of Inference

Conflicts rarely arrive at a crisis point suddenly. They escalate through stages, and de-escalation is possible at every stage — but it becomes harder the longer escalation continues. Understanding the escalation process helps practitioners intervene early and effectively.

## How Conflict Escalates

**1. Discomfort:** Something feels wrong but isn't named. Unresolved, this becomes resentment.

**2. Tension:** The relationship or situation is clearly strained. People avoid the issue.

**3. Incidents:** Specific events reflect underlying conflict. Blame begins to be assigned.

**4. Crisis:** Normal functioning breaks down. Lines are drawn. Resolution requires intervention.

**5. Open Conflict:** Conflict is public, entrenched, and affecting others. Institutional escalation may be required.

## De-escalation Strategies

### Slow down and create space

Urgency and crisis pressure accelerate conflict. Deliberately slow the pace. Pause. Reschedule heated meetings until emotions have settled.

### Separate the people from the problem

Conflict becomes entrenched when people identify personally with their position. Reframe: 'How do we solve this problem together?' not 'Who is right?'

### Find shared interests

Below incompatible positions are usually compatible underlying interests. Identify what both sides actually care about and build from common ground.

### Introduce a neutral third party

When bilateral communication has broken down, a mediator — trusted by both sides — can create conditions for honest dialogue.

**Note: If conflict involves abuse, harassment, or safety, escalate immediately to the appropriate authority — mediation is not appropriate in these cases.**

# Putting It Together: An Ethical Decision-Making Framework

When facing an ethically complex situation, a structured framework helps prevent reactive decisions and ensures important factors are not overlooked. The following six-question process can be applied to any ethical dilemma in community work.

1

## **What exactly is the ethical issue?**

Name it precisely. Is it a conflict of interest? A power imbalance? A harm risk? Vague discomfort is not the same as an ethical problem — clarity is the first step.

2

## **Who is affected — and how?**

Map all stakeholders: who benefits, who is at risk, who has a voice, who doesn't. Pay special attention to those with the least power and the most vulnerability in this specific situation.

3

## **What are the ethical principles at stake?**

Apply the principles from this module: Do no harm? Accountability? Transparency? Power and vulnerability? Non-violence? Use them as a lens, not a checklist.

4

## **What are the realistic options?**

Generate at least three different courses of action. Don't stop at two. More options reveal assumptions and open space for creative, ethical solutions.

5

## **What does each option cost and who bears the cost?**

Every choice has trade-offs. Identify who bears the costs of each option — especially when those costs fall on community members rather than on your organisation.

6

## **Can you justify this decision out loud?**

Imagine explaining it to the affected community, your most demanding critic, and a neutral peer. If any would reasonably find it wrong — reconsider.

**The test of good ethical reasoning:** You cannot always find a perfect solution — sometimes every option causes some harm. Ethical practice is not about perfection; it is about doing the most careful, honest, participatory analysis possible before acting, being transparent about trade-offs, and remaining open to correction when you get it wrong.

## KEY TAKEAWAYS

# Ethics in Community Work

### Power & Vulnerability

Community practitioners always hold power relative to those they serve. Ethical practice means acknowledging this, prioritising community agency, and creating real accountability — especially to the most vulnerable.

### Accountability

Accountability has four directions: downward (to communities), upward (to funders), internal (to your team), and horizontal (to peers). Money, impact claims, and reports are the highest-risk areas for failure.

### Do No Harm

Good intentions do not prevent harm — good practice does. Analyse before acting, monitor during, and be prepared to stop and redesign if your programme is causing unintended harm.

### Non-Violence & Civility

Principled non-violence means channelling disagreement through dialogue, not coercion or dehumanisation. Civility is not suppression of conflict — it is respect for the humanity of those you disagree with.

### Ethics of Volunteering

Volunteering causes harm when skills don't match, when it displaces local workers, or when it serves the volunteer's experience more than the community's needs. Ethical volunteering is led by community need and transfers capacity.

### Managing Conflict

Conflict is normal. The goal is early intervention, honest communication, and separating people from problems. With communities, acknowledge concerns genuinely and always follow through on commitments.